LECTURE 9 :MEETING SKILLS

Introduction

Many meetings take place in business and an effective meeting is an efficient tool in the communication process. Meetings enable face-to-face contact of a number of people at the same time. They provide a useful opportunity for sharing information, making suggestions and proposals, taking decision and obtaining instant feedback. Active participation of all members of the meeting is usually encouraged.

Expected learning outcomes

After studying this unit you should be able to:

■ Explain the purpose of meetings
■ Describe the different types of meetings that take place in business
■ State the documents that are used in the meetings process
■ write a notice and agenda for a meeting
■ write minutes

Purpose of meetings

What meetings are held in your university? Who attends these meetings? Discuss the purpose of these meetings.

Meetings are used for a variety of purposes:

- to co-ordinate or arrange activities
- to give information to a group of people
- to create involvement and interest
- to report on some activity or experience
- to put forward ideas or grievances for discussion
- to obtain assistance

Types of meeting

Meetings can b broadly categorised into two: formal and informal meeting. In the section below we look at what each entails and examples.

Formal meetings

The rules of conduct of formal meetings are laid down in a company's Articles of Association and/or Constitution or Standing Orders. With such meetings a quorum must be present, i.e. the minimum number of people who should be present in order to validate the meeting. A formal record of these meetings must be kept, usually by the company secretary

Examples of formal meetings may include:

a) Statutory meetings

Statutory meetings are called so that the directors and shareholders can communicate and consider special reports. Companies are required by law to hold these statutory meetings.

b) Annual General Meeting (AGM)

AGMs are held once a year to assess the trading of the organisation over the year. All shareholders are invited to attend the AGM but they must be given 21 days' notice.

c) Board meetings

Board meetings are held as often as individual organisations require. They are attended by all directors and chaired by the chairman of the board.

Informal meetings

Informal meetings are not restricted by the same rules and regulations as formal meetings. Such meetings may take the form of brainstorming or discussion sessions where strict agendas may not be necessary and minutes may not be kept. However, it is usually considered good business practice for an agenda to be issued to all members prior to the meeting so that they can prepare adequately in order to make a valuable contribution.

Examples of such meetings may include:

a) Management meetings

These meetings are attended by a group of managers who may need to discuss a specific matter, report on progress or receive progress reports. For example, the marketing manager, sales manager, production manager and research and development manager may meet to discuss the launch of a new product being launched soon.

b) **Departmental meetings**

These meetings are called by the head of department or manager of a certain section. All staff will be invited to attend so that information can be passed on or reports received from some members of staff regarding a specific project.

c) **Working parties**

Working parties may be set up to work together on a specific project or problem. At meetings, progress reports will be given and decisions for further action taken.

Attending meetings

Meetings probably account for 50–60 per cent of a manager's time in business. When they are conducted efficiently, meetings are a very effective way of helping the decision-making process, briefing teams, exchanging information and problem-solving.

However, it is a sad fact that many meetings in business are unproductive because of poor management or because of being unsure of each individual's role in meetings.

As a member of any meeting, even if you are not the chairman, there is a lot you can do to help make meetings effective:

1. Understand the purpose of the meeting, as well as your role and what is expected of you.

2. Read all the papers in advance. Make some notes about any input you would like to make. Do your homework, talk to people who you may be representing at the meeting, get other

people's views on important topics so that you have fuel for any discussions in the meeting.

3. Don't sit there silently. You are a member of the meeting for a reason, so be sure to give your opinions and take an active part in the meeting wherever possible.

4. Do not interrupt anyone who is speaking. Give everyone a chance to voice their own opinions. At an appropriate moment, give some praise if possible first and then give your own views. If you disagree with something, try to be as constructive as possible.

5. Watch the other members of the meeting and listen to them carefully. Watch body language, gestures, eye contact, movements, nuances and all the unique subtleties happening around the table

NOTICE AND AGENDA OF A MEETING

The success of a meeting depends on a variety of essential preparations.

The notice and agenda are usually combined in one document. The portion at the top is known as the notice. The notice gives details of the type, place, day, date and time of the meeting.

The agenda is the list of topics to be discussed at the meeting. On the example shown here note that the first three and final two items are known as ordinary business. These are items which will be included on every meeting agenda. After the opening items of ordinary, business there will be a list of special business – these are special matters to be discussed at this meeting only.
Consider the following example:

KARATINA UNIVERSITY SPORTS CLUB

A meeting of the Sports club to be held in Hall 1 on Friday 29 April, 2020 at 6.00pm

AGENDA

1. Apologies
2. Minutes of the last meeting
3. Maters arising
4. Chairman's report
5. Results of the past football matches
6. Strategy for upcoming matches
7. Annual dinner party
8. Any other Business
9. Date of next meeting

Check point

what's wrong with this?

Study the agenda written as a result of the following scenario. Rewrite the agenda correctly.

As secretary of the Students' Union Group you have been asked by the Chairman to prepare the agenda for the next meeting. In conversation with the Chairman, she said 'The meeting is next Friday – usual time and place. This time we need to have a discussion on lunch-time queues in the refectory – they're becoming very frustrating. There's also the matter of student lockers to be resolved. The provision is quite inadequate, so we need some more urgently. John should be able to give us his report on the recent disco held for charity. Wasn't it a great night? The Students' Common Room is desperately in need of decorating so we must discuss what should be done and nominate someone to take charge. Apart from the usual other items that's about all.

MEETING MINUTES

What are Meeting Minutes?

Meeting minutes are notes that are recorded during a meeting. They highlight the key issues that are discussed, motions proposed or voted on, and activities to be undertaken. The minutes of the meeting are usually taken by a designated member of the group, and they provide an accurate record of what transpired during the meeting.

Steps Involved in Recording Meeting Minutes

There are five main steps involved in recording the minutes of a meeting. They are:

- Pre-planning
- Record-taking
- Writing or transcribing the minutes
- Sharing meeting minutes
- Filing or storage of minutes for referencing in future

Pre-Planning

If a meeting is well-planned in advance, taking minutes will be a lot easier. That said, the chairperson and the secretary or minutes-recorder should work together to determine the agenda of the meeting beforehand. For example, the person recording meetings could work with the chair to draft a document, which serves as an agenda and a format for the minutes.

Meeting Agenda

If it's not possible for the chair and secretary to meet and come up with a draft, then it's up to the secretary to get a copy of the agenda before the meeting starts. The meeting agenda will serve as a guide for how to take notes and prepare the minutes. In addition, the agenda also includes other details, which need to be incorporated in the minutes. They include:

- Names of all the members present – Includes guess and speakers
- Documents that may be handed out as the meeting progresses such as copies of handouts

Expectations

When an individual is chosen as the minutes-recorder, it's important to find out what is expected of him. Therefore, he should approach the chair of the committee and ask what his role in the meeting will be. For example, if the meeting will involve proposing motions, the designated member should inquire whether he should include the names of those proposing motions and those seconding.

What to Include in Meeting Minutes

Before recording any details, a designated minute-recorder should familiarize himself with the type of information that he should record. As mentioned earlier, the committee may be using a specific format to record notes. But overall, the minutes include the following details:

- Date and time the meeting happened
- Names of attendees as well as absent participants
- Acceptance or amendments made to the previous meeting minutes
- Decisions made regarding each item on the list of agenda such as:
    - Activities undertaken or agreed upon
    - Next steps
    - Outcomes from elections
    - Motions accepted or rejected
    - New business
    - Date and time of the next meeting

The Process of Writing Meeting Minutes

When the meeting ends, the individual tasked with writing minutes should get all the resources he needs to write minutes in a clear and more presentable way. Here are some tips to consider:

- Once the meeting ends, don't take too long to write the minutes. This way, everything that took place in the meeting is still fresh in the mind.
- Review the outline that had been created earlier and make adjustments where necessary. It might include adding extra information or clarifying some of the issues raised. Also, check to see that all verdicts, activities, and motions were clearly recorded.
- Revise the minutes and ensure they're brief but clear.

Distributing the Meeting Minutes

Once the secretary completes writing the minutes, he's supposed to share them with the committee members. They can be shared online or through the cloud. Considering that minutes and other types of documents can lead to a lot of paperwork, it's also better to use a paperless sharing approach.

For example, if the minutes-recorder was documenting the minutes using Microsoft Word, which does not offer online sharing, then he should consider converting those records to PDF format and share them through email. Alternatively, one can use Google docs, which offer a way of sharing with other users.

It's not enough to share the minutes to committee members. The secretary is also supposed to save them for future references. Most companies store their minutes online – either in Google Docs or OneDrive.

Summary

Meeting minutes are important as they are used to document the key issues raised during a meeting. For example, effective minutes can state the approaches that were proposed to solve a particular problem and the main reason why members choose one method over the others.

The minutes of the meeting can be recorded manually or on an electronic device such as a laptop or iPad. After the meeting, the secretary reviews the minutes and makes edits where necessary. The meeting minutes are then shared with the participants. Apart from distribution, the minutes are also saved for future references.